

Ramses II

Location: The Grand Atrium (Entrance Hall) inside the Grand Egyptian Museum

Ramesses II, commonly known as Ramesses the Great, was the third pharaoh of the Nineteenth Dynasty of Egypt. He is regarded as the greatest, most celebrated, and most powerful pharaoh of the New Kingdom. He is also considered one of ancient Egypt's most successful warrior pharaohs, conducting no fewer than 15 military campaigns, all resulting in victories except the Battle of Kadesh, which was a stalemate. His 66-year rule was the longest recorded reign of any pharaoh alongside Pepi II, who lived 1000 years earlier.

In ancient Greek sources, he is called Ozymandias, derived from his Egyptian regnal name Usermaatre Setepenre. Contemporary cuneiform letters discovered at Hattusa indicate his name was pronounced Riamessesa and his full titulary pronounced Wasmuriya Satepnaria Riamessesa Maiamana. Ramesses was referred to as the Great God by successor pharaohs and was one of the few pharaohs worshipped as a deity during his lifetime. Scholars dispute his association with the pharaoh of the Exodus.

Early Life

Ramesses II was born around 1303 BC and was not born a prince. His grandfather, Ramesses I, was a vizier and military officer during the reign of Horemheb, who appointed Ramesses I as his successor when Ramesses II was about eleven years old. After Ramesses I died, his son Seti I became king and designated his son Ramesses II as prince regent at about fourteen years old.

Reign and Accession

Ramesses ascended the throne at age 25 on 31 May 1279 BC. Early in his reign, he focused on building cities, temples, and monuments. He established the city of Pi-Ramesses in the Nile Delta, designated it as Egypt's new capital, and used it as the staging point for campaigns in Syria. He celebrated an unprecedented thirteen or fourteen Sed festivals.

Ancient records indicate he died on 13 August 1213 BC (Year 67 of his reign) after reigning for 66 years and 74 days. He died at approximately age 90 or 91.

Upon his death, Ramesses was buried in tomb KV7 in the Valley of the Kings. His body was later moved to the Royal Cache, where it was discovered by archaeologists in 1881. His mummy is on display at the National Museum of Egyptian Civilization in Cairo.

Military Campaigns

During his reign, the Egyptian army totaled approximately 100,000 men. He conducted campaigns in Syria, the Levant, Canaan, Phoenicia, Nubia, and Libya.

- **Campaign Against Sherden Pirates:** In his second regnal year (c. 1278 BC), Ramesses decisively defeated Sherden sea pirates, as well as the Lukka and Shekelesh peoples, along Egypt's Mediterranean coast in a naval battle near the mouth of the Nile. He subsequently incorporated captured Sherden fighters into his personal royal bodyguard.
- **First Syrian Campaign:** In his fourth regnal year (c. 1276 BC), Ramesses led his first Syrian campaign into Canaan and captured the Hittite vassal state of Amurru, commemorating the campaign with a stela at the Dog River near Beirut.
- **Second Syrian Campaign (Battle of Kadesh):** In his fifth regnal year, Ramesses set out for Syria, arriving at Kadesh on 1 May 1274 BC to fight the Hittite forces under Muwatalli II. After being caught in a Hittite ambush, Egyptian reinforcements arrived, allowing Ramesses to counterattack and route the Hittites. Though Ramesses claimed victory, the campaign ended in a stalemate and Egyptian forces retreated, allowing Hittites to briefly occupy Egyptian possessions around Damascus.
- **Third Syrian Campaign:** In the seventh year of his reign (April/May 1272 BC), Ramesses returned to Syria. He split his army into two forces: one led by his son Amunher-khepeshef (which captured Edom-Seir and Moab), and one led by Ramesses himself (which attacked Jerusalem and Jericho). Reuniting in Moab, the combined army captured Hesbon, Damascus, Kumidi, and Upi.
- **Later Syrian Campaigns:** In his eighth and ninth years, Ramesses pushed north into Amurru and captured Dapur, as well as towns in Retjenu and Tunip in Naharin, returning to Heliopolis by November 1272 BC. He campaigned against Dapur again in his tenth year (1269 BC) alongside six of his sons. On 19 January 1261 BC (his eighteenth regnal year), he erected a stela at Beth Shean.

Peace Treaty with the Hittites

In Year 21 of Ramesses's reign (c. 1259 BC), he concluded a peace treaty with the Hittites, known to modern scholars as the Treaty of Kadesh. While it settled disputes over Canaan, its immediate cause was a diplomatic crisis following Hattusili III's accession to the Hittite throne. Hattusili had deposed his nephew Mursili III in a brief Hittite civil war. Mursili III went into exile in Syria, but fled to Egypt after attempting to regain power.

Hattusili demanded Mursili's extradition, but Ramesses II denied knowing his whereabouts and suggested Hattusili was being deceived by his subjects. This precipitated a crisis that brought both empires close to war. On 10 November 1259 BC (I Peret 21 of Year 21), Ramesses received the Hittite peace treaty tablets, concluding an agreement at Kadesh to end the conflict.

The treaty survived in two language versions: Egyptian hieroglyphs and Hittite cuneiform script. While mostly identical across its 18 articles, the versions differ in tone: the Hittite text states the Egyptians sued for peace, whereas the Egyptian version states the Hittites sued for peace. The treaty was given to the Egyptians on a silver plaque, which was brought back to Egypt and carved into the temple at Karnak. The treaty called for peace between Egypt and Hatti, invoked their respective deities to demand peace, and established that times of intrigue supporting Mursili III had passed.

While exact borders were not laid out in the text, the Anastasy A papyrus describes Phoenician coastal towns under Egyptian control during the latter part of Ramesses II's reign, identifying the harbor town of Sumur (north of Byblos) as the northernmost Egyptian town containing a garrison. No further Egyptian campaigns in Canaan are recorded after this treaty, and the northern border remained quiet and secure until Ramesses II's death. When the King of Mira tried to involve Ramesses against the Hittites, Ramesses refused. Similarly, Hattusili III wrote to Kadashman-Enlil II (Kassite king of Kardunias/Babylon) encouraging him to oppose the King of Assyria, whose allies had killed an Egyptian messenger, to prevent Assyria from cutting connections between Egypt's Canaanite province and Mursili III.

Nubian Campaigns

Ramesses II campaigned south of the first cataract of the Nile into Nubia, a region that had been an Egyptian colony for 200 years. At around age 22, Ramesses was accompanied on at least one Nubian campaign by two of his young sons, Amun-her-khepeshef and Khaemwaset.

These military actions were recorded in temple decorations built by Ramesses II at Beit el-Wali, Gerf Hussein, and Kalabsha in northern Nubia. On the south wall of the Beit el-Wali temple, Ramesses II is depicted charging in a war chariot against southern tribes, with his two sons behind him in their own chariots. A wall inscription in one of his temples records that he fought one battle against these tribes without assistance from his soldiers.

Libyan Campaigns

During his reign, Egypt maintained political and military control over a 300-kilometer stretch of the Mediterranean coast as far west as Zawyet Umm El Rakham, where the remains of an Egyptian fortress built on Libyan land were discovered.

There are no detailed accounts of large-scale military actions against the Libyans under Ramesses II, only generalized records of him conquering them. Some records, such as the Aswan Stele from Year 2 of his reign, may refer back to his participation in his father Seti I's earlier Libyan campaigns. Seti I may have originally planned and established this coastal defense system similarly to the Ways of Horus across Northern Sinai.

Sed Festivals

By Year 28 of his reign, ostraca from Deir el-Medina indicate that Ramesses II favored the god Amun above all other divinities.

In the 30th year of his reign, Ramesses celebrated his first Sed festival (jubilee) to honor and rejuvenate his pharaonic strength. By this midpoint of his 66-year reign, he had established peace, secured Egypt's borders, built numerous monuments, and overseen a period of national prosperity.

While Sed festivals were traditionally celebrated every three years following the 30th regnal year, Ramesses II sometimes held them after two-year intervals, ultimately celebrating an unprecedented thirteen or fourteen Sed festivals during his lifetime.

Building Projects and Monuments

In the third year of his reign, Ramesses II began the most ambitious building project since the construction of the pyramids 1,500 years earlier, covering Egypt from the Delta to Nubia with monuments. His architectural strategy included remodeling or usurping existing structures, deepening relief engravings into stone to prevent easy erasure and make them stand out in the sun, and using art as political propaganda to depict his foreign victories. His cartouches were placed on many buildings, including those he did not build.

- **Pi-Ramesses:** Founded a new capital city in the eastern Delta (at modern Qantir, 30 km south of its former misidentified location, Tanis). Formerly a summer palace under Seti I, the new capital was named *Pi-Ramesses Aa-nakhtu* ("Domain of Ramesses, Great in Victory") and featured large temples, a royal palace, and a zoo. Today, only colossal feet from his statue remain above ground.
- **Ramesseum:** A massive mortuary temple built in western Thebes between Qurna and the desert.
 - Features a ruined syenite statue of the enthroned pharaoh measuring 17 meters high and weighing over 1,000 tonnes.
 - Pylon walls depict scenes of Ramesses II and his army defeating Hittite forces at the Battle of Kadesh, as well as festivals honoring the fertility deity Min.
 - Contains a great hypostyle hall measuring 41 by 31 meters with 39 of its original 48 columns still standing, featuring ceiling decorations of gold stars on a blue background.
 - Surrounded by mud-brick storerooms and the remains of a school for scribes.
 - Stood adjacent to a temple of Seti I, of which only foundations remain.
- **Abu Simbel:** Inaugurated in 1255 BC during a trip to Nubia with Queen Nefertari, this rock-cut temple complex served to elevate Ramesses II to divine status. It was rediscovered in 1813 by Johann Ludwig Burckhardt and first entered on 4 August 1817 by Giovanni Battista Belzoni.
- **Other Nubian Monuments:** Constructed temples at Derr and Gerf Hussein (relocated to New Kalabsha alongside scenes on the walls of the Temple of Beit el-Wali), and shaped the Temple of Amun at Jebel Barkal (originally founded under Thutmose III).
- **Gold Mining:** Expanded gold mining operations at Akuyati (modern Wadi Allaqi).

Recent Archaeological Discoveries

- **Memphis Colossus:** An 83-tonne, 3,200-year-old statue found in six pieces near Memphis. Erected in Ramesses Square (Cairo) in 1955, it was relocated in August 2006 to a site near the Grand Egyptian Museum to protect it from exhaust fumes.
- **Matariya Seat Fragment (2018):** Excavations in Cairo's Matariya neighborhood uncovered a four-step royal platform used for celebrations such as his inauguration and Sed festivals, alongside scarabs, amulets, and engraved blocks.

- **Mit Rahina Granite Ka Bust (December 2019):** A rare red granite bust (55 cm wide, 45 cm thick, 105 cm long) showing Ramesses II wearing a wig with the "Ka" symbol was unearthed in Giza, along with Heb-Sed limestone blocks. It is the first granite "Ka" statue ever discovered.
- **Granite Sarcophagus Fragment (May 2023):** Sorbonne archaeologists identified a fragment of Ramesses II's original granite sarcophagus (dating to c. 1279–1213 BC), which had been reused around 1000 BC by the 21st Dynasty High Priest Menkheperre.
- **Golden Sword (September 2024):** A 3,200-year-old military fort excavated along the Nile yielded a golden sword inscribed with the signature of Ramesses II.

Death and Burial

The last recorded date of Ramesses II's reign is Year 67, I Akhet, day 18, followed shortly by Year 1, II Akhet, day 18 of his successor, Merneptah. Decades later, Ramesses IV left an inscription at Abydos confirming Ramesses II reigned for 67 years. Ancient historians like Manetho assign him a reign of 66 years and 2 months, placing his death at approximately age 90 in early Year 67 of his reign.

At the time of his death, Ramesses II suffered from severe dental problems, a jaw abscess (a possible cause of death via severe infection), arthritis, hardening of the arteries, heart disease, and diffuse idiopathic skeletal hyperostosis, which caused a pronounced hunch in his posture.

Mummy History & Analysis

- **Tomb & Relocations:** Originally buried in tomb KV7 in the Valley of the Kings. Due to rampant looting, priests re-wrapped his body and transferred it to the tomb of Queen Ahmose Inhapy, then 72 hours later to the tomb of High Priest Pinedjem II (recorded in hieroglyphics on his coffin's linen). His mummy was discovered by archaeologists in 1881 inside tomb TT320 within a reused wooden coffin.
- **Physical Characteristics:**
 - Height: Approximately 1.7 meters (5 ft 7 in).
 - Features: Aquiline nose, strong jaw, thin beard/mustache, and thin, wavy red hair measuring 5 centimeters in length.
 - Microscopic and forensic examination conducted in Paris in 1976 confirmed the red hair was natural rather than artificial dye, linking his lineage symbolically to the deity Set (associated with red hair).
- **Forensic Study in France (1976–1977):** In September 1976, President Valéry Giscard d'Estaing arranged for the mummy to be flown to Paris for restoration at the Musée de l'Homme to eliminate fungal growth and insects using irradiation. It was returned to Egypt in May 1977.
- **Relic Theft (2006):** French police arrested a man attempting to sell stolen tufts of Ramesses II's hair online; the relics were returned to Egypt in 2007.
- **Museum Displays:** Formerly kept at the Egyptian Museum in Tahrir, his mummy was transferred to the National Museum of Egyptian Civilization on 3 April 2021 as part of the "Pharaohs' Golden Parade."

Summary:

- **Age & Regnal Lifespan:** Died at approximately 90 years old after reigning for 66 full years and entering his 67th regnal year (c. 1279–1213 BC).
- **Lineage & Origin:** Originated from the northeastern nome of Northern Egypt (unlike dynasties from Upper/Southern Egypt).
 - **Father:** Seti I
 - **Grandfather:** Ramesses I (served as High Priest of Set under Amenhotep III)
- **Family:**
 - **Queen:** Nefertari
 - **Sons:** Amun-her-khepeshef and Khaemwaset (who joined him on military campaigns in Nubia when Ramesses was around age 22), among other children depicted in temple reliefs.
- **Physical Appearance:**
 - **Height:** Approximately 1.7 meters (5 ft 7 in).
 - **Facial Features:** Aquiline nose, strong jaw, thin beard and mustache.
 - **Hair:** Naturally red, slightly wavy, about 5 cm long (white at the time of death, dyed light red/auburn with henna during mummification). His natural red hair symbolically linked his family to the deity Set.
- **Health & Medical Conditions:**
 - Suffered from severe dental issues and a major jaw abscess.
 - Plagued by severe arthritis, hardening of the arteries, and heart disease in his later years.
 - Diagnosed with diffuse idiopathic skeletal hyperostosis, which caused him to walk with a pronounced stoop or hunched back.
- **Death & Cause of Death:** Died in early Year 67 of his reign. While the exact cause of death is unknown, a severe infection from his jaw abscess is considered a probable cause.
- **Burial & Mummy History:**
 - Originally buried in tomb **KV7** in the Valley of the Kings.
 - Relocated by priests due to tomb looting first to the tomb of Queen Ahmose Inhapy, then to High Priest Pinedjem II's tomb, before being rediscovered in 1881 in **TT320**.
 - Traveled to Paris in 1976 for forensic testing and fungal radiation treatment.
 - Currently housed in the **National Museum of Egyptian Civilization** in Cairo following the 2021 Pharaohs' Golden Parade.